



**CHANGING BASES OF SOCIAL
CATEGORIZATION AND INTERGROUP
RELATIONSHIP**

THESIS

SUBMITTED FOR THE AWARD OF DEGREE OF

Doctor of Philosophy

In

Psychology

BY

VIKRANT JHA

UNDER THE SUPERVISION OF

**PROF. SHAH MOHD. KHAN
PROFESSOR**

**DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY
ALIGARH MUSLIM UNIVERSITY
ALIGARH-202002 (INDIA)**

2023

Chapter–4

Discussion, Conclusions, Implications, Limitations and Future Directions

Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University

Chapter – 4

Discussion, Conclusions, Implications, Limitations and Future Directions

This study is designed to understand the changing bases of social categorization and intergroup relationship through investigating the following aims: (1) to identify the dominant typologies of everyday discrimination and the role of social categorization, (2) to examine how in-group and out-group identification predicting social distance towards members of out-group, (3) to assess intergenerational effects on social categorization and intergroup relationship and, (4) to understand the category salience and intergroup relationship in cross-categorization situation. In accordance with the study's goal, the main findings from each phase are provided. This chapter highlights the noteworthy findings and presents them in an overall picture by utilizing the literature that already exists. Furthermore, this chapter offers insights into the implications for theory, methodology, and practice of this study. This research paper concludes by discussing the final remarks, constraints encountered during the study, and potential future directions for further investigation.

4.1 Discussion

4.1.1 Aim 1

Intergroup bias and discrimination are commonly perceived as inevitable consequences of a typical, inherent, and widespread cognitive process that serves to simplify the complex dynamics of the social realm (Hamilton, 1981a). Hence, this observation appears to elucidate the reasons behind the pervasive, persistent, and nearly ubiquitous nature of prejudice and discrimination as social phenomena. Consequently, phase I was designed to address the aim one and its main question: What are the most dominant typologies of discrimination along which people face discrimination in their daily life and how are they distributed across individuals' demographics? Also, how do these typologies interact to provide the bases for unfair treatment that people receive in everyday life? Key findings of this study are presented according to sub-questions that are enlisted earlier.

To address the first sub-question, parent nodes were prepared after word frequency analysis based on participants open-ended responses on Everyday Discrimination Scale (EDS) that treated as references in NVivo 11+. Fourteen parent nodes were generated in which participants reported incidents of higher

discrimination on their age, gender, language, place, cast, socioeconomic status, race and ethnicity, achievement, religion, education, physical appearance, disability, and lifestyle also few participants reported absence of discrimination that we considered here as a parent node. These nodes gave rise to the notion that one of the fundamental components that adults include in their representations of the social environment is the concept that certain category memberships constitute an inherent component of an individual's identity. According to Haslam et al. (2000), adults are prone to easily form beliefs regarding gender, race, ethnicity, sexual orientation, and religious categories.

In this phase, four most prevalent typologies of discrimination along which individuals received unfair treatment were socioeconomic status, gender, age and education where the four least prevalent typologies of discrimination are race and ethnicity, achievement, disability and lifestyle. These dimensions are consistent with the dimensions taken by Oxfam India (2022) in their Indian discrimination report 2022. Findings of this phase are *concurrently validated* with the studies of Grigoryan (2020) and Grigoryan et al. (2022).

According to Article 15 (1) of the Constitution of India (1950), it is prohibited to engage in discrimination solely based on religion, race, caste, sex, or place of birth. The article further asserts that the state must not discriminate against any citizen solely on the basis of these factors. However, it is evident that the actual implementation of these laws falls short of their intended objectives. The Constitution of India (1950) additionally stipulates that no individual shall be subjected to any form of disability, liability, restriction, or condition solely based on their religion, race, caste, sex, or any combination thereof. This prohibition applies specifically to the following areas: (a) the ability to access shops, public restaurants, hotels, and venues for public entertainment, and (b) the utilization of wells, tanks, roads, and public spaces that are either fully or partially funded by the State or designated for the general public's use.

To address the second sub-question, frequency data are extracted from NVivo 11+ to IBM SPSS (Statistical Package for Social Sciences) version 28, bar graphs were prepared to see the distribution of references of incidents of nodes along participants' age (young/old), gender (male/female) and area of living (urban/rural).

Graphs revealed that women are more prone to face discrimination on their gender and physical appearances than men because they were not given much freedom of jobs and do not get equal pay as reported by participants. The aforementioned observation aligns with the findings presented in the Oxfam India report (2022), which suggests that gender-based discrimination accounts for 98% of the disparity in employment rates between male and female individuals in urban regions. Results also suggest that females face less discrimination on their age, language, place of belonging, achievements, religion, and education because of their limited social contact in Indian society. This finding contradicts the finding of Moreno-Bella (2023) who suggests that in the context of elevated levels of inequality, there was an observed amplification in the perceived level of agency ascribed to men compared to women, while the disparity in perceived levels of communion between men and women diminished.

Male participants faced more discriminatory actions on their age, language, place of belonging, achievements, religion, education because they face constant pressure of earning well and go outside to work. This observation gets support from Jha and Khan (2023) who suggests that both males and females encounter various types of discriminatory actions similarly. However, there are differences observed in the specific scenarios in which males and females experience discrimination.

Young participants reported more incidents of discrimination on their gender, language, cast, socioeconomic status, race and ethnicity, achievements, religion, physical appearance because they have higher social and occupational contacts at workplace and within the society as compared to older participants. Older people reported more incidents of discrimination against them on their age, education and disability due to their reduced social contact and care from their children as major determinants of their loneliness. In this study we observed a clear pattern in typologies of discrimination in urban and rural area. In urban area discriminatory actions against individuals were higher on their socioeconomic status, race and ethnicity, achievements, religion, physical appearance and lifestyle due to having an urge to adapt in urban culture and whereas individuals who were belonging to rural area reported more discrimination than individuals from urban area on their age, education, and disability because of lack of education and ability to earn well.

In pursuit of subsequent aims, we adhered to the premise provided by Miller et al. (1990) and Miller and Bersoff (1992) that the structure of Indian society offered a fertile ground for the examination of the interactive roles of multiple identities, such as religious, national, regional (North vs. South), class, and caste, and how one could either discard or fuse these identities for the benefit of societal functioning. The structure of Indian society offered a fertile ground for the examination of these interactive roles.

4.1.2 Aim 2

In multiple domains of human experience, the process of categorization commences by observing and giving attention to specific criteria that are pertinent for the identification of categories (Quinn, 2011). Consequently, in aim 2 we examined how in-group and out-group identification predict social distance towards members of out-group for their highly preferred social category because an essential element of social categorization pertains to the differentiation between the group encompassing the individual (referred to as the in-group) and other groups (known as the out-groups). This distinction establishes an unambiguous boundary between the collective identities of "us" versus "them" (Tajfel & Turner 1979; Turner et al. 1987). Chi-square goodness of fit test shed light on that the eight social categories were used in aim 3 and aim 4 remained mutually exclusive and independent in terms of their preferences across participants due to their unique psychological relevance and expression. Among eight social categories education and religion are highly preferred by participants followed by economic group and the least preferred social categories are lingual, age and caste.

Further correlation analysis shed light on findings that in-group and out-group identifications are not significantly correlated with each in majority of social categories except for place in which relationship was weak negative, this could be due to the perceived outsiders threat that people perceive at a place. The present finding presents a contradiction to the results of a prior study conducted by Phelps et al. (2013), which demonstrated that individuals belonging to the in-group tend to perceive out-group members negatively when they are subjected to negative evaluations by indicated out-group members. For economic group in which relationship is weak positive this could be due to out-group act as comparison group that generates a sense of superiority if members of in-group belongs to economically

strong group and members of out-group belongs to economically weaker section; and when members of in-group belongs economically weak group they have longing to strive to become the member of their out group that is they want to come in economically strong group. Furthermore, the outcomes of the study provided further support for the previously established conclusions that identification is a significant predictor of heightened bias, particularly in instances where the participant is affiliated with a higher social status and the target is associated with a lower social status group (Grigoryan et al., 2022).

Participants' identification towards their own group was correlation with their intensity of social distance and their perceived social distance only in preferred social categories religion and education and it was seen that this association was positive, and for other preferred social categories, identification of people with their own group was not significantly associated with display of higher social distance intensity and perceived social distance. The results of the Pew Research Center's (2012) research, which showed that more than 80% of people worldwide identify as members of a religious group, are again underlined by this finding. Participants' identification towards their out-group was found to negatively associate with their intensity of social distance towards out-group and their perceived social distance in majority of social categories except for biologically relevant social categories (age and gender). Additionally, we also found that people who perceived higher social distance they also displayed higher social distance intensity in each social categories preferred by participants as their preferred social category.

The regression analysis provided insights into the findings that in-group-out-group identification jointly predicts perceived social distance in majority of social categories preferred by participants except for biologically based social categories (age and gender) while in-group-out-group identification jointly predicted social distance intensity in all the social categories preferred by participants as their preferred social category except for age. From regression models it was observed that out-group identification emerged as significant negative predictor of perceived social distance and social distance intensity whereas in-group identification was emerged as positive predictor in majority of social categories but also as negative predictor in few social categories (language and gender). From regression models it was clear that the contribution of negative out-group identification was higher than positive or negative

in-group identification in predicting perceived social distance or social distance intensity and the majority, if not all, of contemporary prevailing theories posit that group affiliation and belongingness are not considered as independent motivations, but rather as mechanisms for the satisfaction of other important individual and collective needs (Correll & Park, 2005).

4.1.3 Aim 3

Long et al. (2022) concludes that utilization of imagined contact has proven to be an effective method in enhancing the younger generation's capacity to empathize with and understand the perspectives of older individuals. In nearly all societies, every successive generation undergoes distinct experiences in life. According to Clausen (1986), each generation faces unique themes and problems that are often distinct from those experienced by their parents. Therefore, initially we wanted to see the mean difference on in-group-identification, out-group identification and social distance intensity across eight social categories used in this study. Results revealed that in-group identification and out-group identification significantly varied across eight social categories along with social distance intensity. People who preferred economic group as their preferred social category identified least with their in-group and this in-group identification remained equal in lingual, religion, place, education, and caste. People who preferred religion as their preferred social category identified least with their out-group members and higher out-group identification was seen for people who preferred age and gender. Those people who preferred religion as their preferred social category displayed higher intensity of social distance followed by caste, education and language and it was observed least for age and gender. The mean rank of perceived social distance was also found to be higher for those people who preferred religion as their preferred social category followed by caste and it was observed least for gender and age. The observed results may potentially be attributed to the assertion made by Haslam et al. (2000) that sociocultural groups tend to be essentialized, thereby limiting opportunities for alteration or influence.

Van Rossem (2018) stated that the social identity perspective remains consistent with generational identity theory, therefore, after examining the mean differences on in-group-identification, out-group identification and social distance intensity, and also assessing the perceived social distance; for aim 3, we grouped the data of participants based on their age and the four generational cohorts to which they

belonged because neither the social distance intensity nor the perceived social distance is predicted by in-group-out-group identification when it comes to age as the participants' most preferred social category in aim 2. The findings revealed significant intergenerational effects on in-group identification in age and gender, intergenerational effects on out-group identification was observed in lingual, religion and caste also Gen X and Boomers identified less toward members of out-group than Gen Z and Gen Y. Intergenerational effects on social distance intensity were seen in age, religion and caste as individuals' preferred social categories. Intergenerational effects on perceived social distance were seen in age, religion, place, caste and economic group as suggested by Kruskal-Wallis rank sum test. In this study we observed that patterns of ranking of social categories by their importance were found to be significant in each generational cohort. Gen Z and Gen Y highly preferred education as their preferred social category and shown least preference for caste. Gen X and Boomers highly preferred religion and Gen X displayed least preference for age category whereas Boomers displayed least preference for gender it could be because in collectivist culture people have stronger tendency to not prefer biologically based social category and in as people move towards old age they develop higher acceptance for their age and gender.

4.1.4 Aim 4

The existing body of research on crossed and multiple categorizations indicates that individuals employ multiple bases of categorization concurrently when developing impressions of others (Crisp & Hewstone, 2007; Crisp, Hewstone, & Cairns, 2001). The fourth aim of the research was to better understand category salience and intergroup relationships under cross-categorization settings. For this we maintained the psychological relevance of social categories used in current research based on their scores of social distance intensity reflected from table 3.6 from result section. In cross-categorization conditions dimensions of religion were crossed with caste, dimensions of age were crossed with gender, dimensions of language were with place, and dimensions of educational group with economic group. We tested the baseline pattern of cross-categorization evaluation (additive pattern) for social identification of whole sample and also on their sample characteristics (double in-group membership) and if patterns fails to follow the additive pattern then we looked

for another pattern of cross-categorization and it said to be emergence of category salience, all these patterns were adopted by Crisp & Hewstone, (2007).

Religion emerged as salient social category than caste across religion-caste cross-categorization condition in whole sample. Religion emerged as dominant social category for social categorization than caste for those people whose double in-group membership were religious unreserved and religious reserved. Additive pattern were found for people those people whose double in-group membership were non-religious unreserved and non-religious reserved, consequently no category salience was observed for members of these groups. This again suggested that religion is dominant and salient social category than caste for social identification across religion-caste cross-categorization condition India. The rationale behind this finding is elucidated by Hogg et al. (2010), who present empirical support indicating that religion exhibits an outstanding ability to reduce uncertainty. This is attributed to the highly cohesive nature of religious groups and their unique focus on existential matters, a characteristic not commonly found in other social groups. When an individual's self-concept is closely tied to their religious identity, the presence of religious out-groups can be particularly unsettling. This is due to the introduction of ambiguity, which challenges the coherence and validity of the fundamental principles that underpin an individual's worldview.

Across age-gender cross-categorization for whole sample additive pattern was found and people gave equal weightage to both the categories hence no salient category was emerged. Similar results were obtained for young male and old female participants whereas among young female gender category emerged salient social category and among old male age emerged as salient social category for social identification across age-gender cross-categorization condition. Language emerged as salient social category than place for participants across language-place cross-categorization condition to socially identify with other people.

In education-economic cross-categorization condition, for whole sample additive pattern was observed hence there was no category salience between educational and economic category and people provided equal importance to both the social categories. Also, this additive pattern was found for people whose double in-group membership was economically strong and illiterate whereas people who were from economically weak and illiterate group favoured economic identification. People

with economically weak and literate double in-group membership also favoured economic identification but economically strong and literate people were inclined towards educational identification. These findings suggested that across education-economic cross-categorization condition participants double in-group membership have a significant role on salience of social category. This draws attention to the problem that, as economic inequality rises, membership in a certain social class becomes more obvious and significant as a marker of differentiation, acting as a subliminal indicator of another person's worth (Heiserman & Simpson, 2017).

4.1.5 General Discussion

This thesis sought to understand and examine the “changing bases of social categorization and intergroup relationship”. Although literature provides sufficient evidences about changing nature of social categorization and its associated intergroup relationship between various groups in India and throughout the world. However in this thesis researcher adopted empirical approach and utilized exploratory sequential mix-method design to investigate the various bases of social categorization and its resulting intergroup relationship.

The study includes two phases: phase I (qualitative) that builds phase II (quantitative). This study employed adult participants due to the fact that adults possess a natural inclination to categorize individuals into social groups, which subsequently influence their various cognitive processes, such as learning, reasoning, perception, and behaviour, have been extensively studied by researchers (Kawakami et al., 2002; Lickel et al., 2000; Turner et al., 1994). According to Karnadewi and Lipp (2011), adults exhibit swift encoding of social category information, including race, gender, and age, when presented with individual faces. The phenomenon of social categorization is known to influence memory processes, as evidenced by the finding that adults' exhibit superior memory for information that aligns with stereotypes compared to information that contradicts stereotypes (Bodenhausen, 1988).

The phenomenon of social categorization serves as the foundation for intergroup processes that occur prior to the manifestation of prejudice and discrimination (Bigler & Liben, 2006). Therefore, in the first phase, the researcher employs a culture-sensitive approach to select dimensions and categories in order to

identify dominant typologies of everyday discrimination. According to Brewer and Pickett (2002), Optimal Distinctiveness Theory posits that an individual's inclination to adopt or identify with a specific social identity is influenced by two factors: the strength of their desire to assimilate or differentiate, and their perception of the inclusiveness of the relevant social group in the given context.

Eight dominant typologies are selected and used as social categories in phase II. Categories play a crucial role in cognitive efficiency by enabling individuals to make inferences about unfamiliar individuals (Quinn, 2011; Rips, 1975). Tajfel and Turner (1986) emphasize that individuals exhibit in-group favouritism and out-group prejudice as a means of bolstering social identity, thereby increasing the self-esteem of group members. Consequently, these social categories were presented to the participants and asked them to rank by importance to their life. Participants' in-group and out-group identification and social distance towards out-group were measured with respect to their highly preferred social category. It was found that in-group and out-group identification was not significantly correlated for majority of social categories but found negatively correlated for place and positively correlated for economic group. People who preferred religion and educational group as their preferred social category shown positive association with segments of social distance (social distance intensity and perceived social distance) to their out-group members. Out-group identification of participants towards members of out-group on their highly preferred social category negatively correlated with segments of social distance (social distance intensity and perceived social distance) in majority of social categories except for age and gender because Shi et al. (2022) observed that individuals exhibit a stronger inclination towards social distancing when faced with higher levels of perceived threats compared to situations with lower levels of relevant threats. Both the segments of social distance correlated positively with each other this implying that people who perceive broaden social distance also display higher social distance intensity towards members of out-group. Phase II also revealed that out-group identification emerged as negative predictor of social distance intensity and perceived social distance for majority for social categories, whereas participants' in-group identification emerged as significant positive predictor of social distance intensity and perceived social distance only for religion and education.

Intergenerational differences on in-group identification were found for age and gender, whereas on out-group identification intergenerational differences were seen for language, religion and caste. Generational cohorts significantly differed in their display of social distance intensity for age, religion and caste as participants' highly preferred social category but on perceived social distance intergenerational differences were found to be significant for age, religion, place, caste and educational group. The results indicates that lingual bases of categorization is latent and causing factor in hindering the social contact hence language plays a dominant role in increasing social distance between groups because from developmental perspective Gelman and Roberts (2017) demonstrates that when adults use language to make general statements about categories, it significantly contributes to the formation of children's beliefs that these categories represent essential similarities among members within the category and differences between different groups.

In cross-categorization conditions, religion emerged salient social category than caste for whole sample, participants who belonged to religious unreserved group and religious reserved group whereas no category salience was observed for participants who belonged to non-religious unreserved and non-religious reserved group. Language emerged salient social category than place of belonging for whole sample. The findings of this study offer robust evidence in favour of the additive model of crossed categorization, which contradicts the notion that category-based information processing diminishes with an expanding number of categories (Grigoryan, 2020), similarly when age crossed with gender no category salience was found for whole sample. Participants belonged to young male, and old female group whereas young female favoured their gender category and old male favoured their age category. In economic-education cross categorization condition additive pattern was observed for whole sample but varied when we assessed it on participants' double in-group membership.

4.2 Conclusions

This research explored the changing bases of social categorization and intergroup relationship. It was shown that social categorization process is ever changing multidimensional construct that influence in-group relationship on each social categorization dimension. Phase I suggested that people in their everyday life reported unfair treatment highly based on their socioeconomic status, gender, age,

religion, education, caste, place, language and also shown demographic variations in their expression. These activated social categories were mutually exclusive in terms of their expression and distribution.

Phase II suggested that religion and educational group were most frequently preferred social category that together incorporated almost 49% of our total sample. Further, participants' negative out-group identification on their highly preferred social category towards members of out-group was correlated with their social distance towards out-group members. Phase II also revealed that out-group identification emerged as negative predictor of social distance intensity and perceived social distance for majority for social categories whereas participants' in-group identification emerged as significant positive predictor of social distance intensity and perceived social distance only for religion and education social category. This research revealed that intergenerational differences on different measures (in-group identification, out-group identification and segments of social distance) were found to be significant for only few preferred social categories. In cross-categorization conditions religion and language significantly emerged as salient social category for social identification towards other groups with respect to their psychologically relevant social category. Cross-categorization conditions shown variations in category salience when we assessed different conditions based on participants' double in-group membership and evaluated on different patterns of social categorization adopted by Crisp & Hewstone, (2007).

The research findings were examined in relation to existing theoretical and empirical literature, and significant theoretical, methodological, and practical implications were presented.

4.3 Implications

The present study holds significant implications in terms of theory, methodology, and practical applications.

4.3.1 Theoretical

This study is interdisciplinary in nature, utilizing literature, theories, and concepts from various fields of study such as anthropology, cognitive psychology, social psychology, and sociology to emphasize the relevance and importance of understanding the changing bases of social categorization and intergroup relationships

in the new millennium. This research work makes a contribution and adds to the body of literature in the field of social identity perspective and intergroup relation researches. It also redounds to the benefits of understanding the new and existing dominant social categories in India and its influence on the relationship between in-group and out-group identification.

While this study did not show full significant quantitative support for the patterns of crossed categorization adopted in aim four (adopted from Crisp & Hewstone, 2007), it did attempt to test hypotheses in a collectivist culture. It reported pertinent knowledge about the salience of social categories in crossed-categorization conditions, so we advocate that these patterns need to be tested, validated, and expanded in different cultural contexts.

This research has significance for widening the conceptualizations of social categorization tradition and its associated intergroup behaviours. Additionally, the integration of findings across qualitative and quantitative phases has produced functional shreds of evidence and premises on the changing nature of social categorization. On various dominant social categories, there appears to be support for flexible patterns of social categorization and associated intergroup relations such as social distance. Nevertheless, these patterns were heavily based on ideas pertaining to social cognition and the social identity perspective.

This study emphasizes the need for more research into the causes and effects of category activation on relationships between people belonging to the same group and those from different groups.

4.3.2 Methodological

This study's findings and experiences can help to shape the design of mixed methods research. Taxonomies are helpful because they shorten the time it takes to explain different approaches to study. However, they don't always precisely reflect the methodology actually utilized. Because of the challenges that are linked with these types of study designs, two crucial considerations need to be made by researchers who employ mixed methods. The first question that has to be answered is whether or not sequential mixed-methods studies should be designed in a manner that gives sufficient time for the comprehensive gathering of data and analysis of that data? Is it necessary to undertake consecutive investigations in a particular order? Furthermore, what

strategies can researchers employ to successfully present a sequential mixed methods proposal to their dissertation committee in a manner that adheres to the study design while also allowing for significant modifications to be made during the second phase of the investigation? Due to the relatively recent emergence of mixed methods research, it is imperative to engage in further discourse and elucidation of these matters in order to progress the methodology of mixed methods research (Creswell & Tashakkori, 2007).

In our particular study, during the first phase, we used unique approach to generate the nodes (codes) that were subsequently investigated as social categories during the second phase of the research. These nodes were regarded to be the dominating typologies of everyday discrimination. Using the results of the qualitative phase, we constructed a question about our preferences for social categories and then conducted a quantitative analysis. Because self-reports have the potential to be skewed by social desirability, the survey schedule was drafted using pre-existing measures on social categorization and intergroup relationships. This was done in order to account for the potential for bias in the data. Even implicit attitudes are susceptible to manipulation in the study of bias (Fiedler & Bluemke, 2005). There exist many convincing arguments for asserting that the concern of social desirability does not significantly undermine the credibility of our findings. The effectiveness of survey schedules in reducing social desirability bias has been demonstrated in various studies, particularly in relation to prejudice and discrimination (Armacost et al., 1991; Auspurg et al., 2014; Liebig et al., 2015). These results have been found to be consistent across a number of different research works.

The addition of the item that measures the desire to intermingle with the sample increases the external validity of our results, and there are numerous directions for further investigation that might be made using the current dataset or new data using this methodology. Consequently, the outcomes of this research offer empirical support that can serve as a catalyst and guide for future discussions on optimizing the efficacy of mixed-methods studies.

4.3.3 Practical

This study aligns with the objectives of sustainable development, encompassing the eradication of disparities, the establishment of sustainable urban

areas and communities, the promotion of peace, justice, and robust institutions, the cultivation of partnerships to attain the objectives, and the assurance of optimal health and well-being for all individuals. This research has applications in policymaking, instilling a shared sense of identity among individuals and communities, fostering cooperative efforts to achieve shared goals, and promoting healthy rivalries as means of combating bias of all kinds. The findings and literature of this research provide suggestions to policy developers for developing intervention programs and awareness programs in which individuals become familiar with and understand the cultural and religious values of different groups. The present study will serve as an essential foundation for subsequent research endeavours in India pertaining to the concept of group tolerance, the schematic rigidity of dominant social categories, community harmony, and peace-building through positive social categorization and de-categorization, new ways of reducing implicit and explicit individual and group-based discrimination in India. This study also focused on the cross-categorization process, therefore the study's findings aided in comprehending individuals' belongingness to salient social categories and how individuals identified with other social groups in cross-categorization conditions.

This study has the potential to provide insights and remedies concerning the appropriate utilization of social categorization by political leaders and the government to develop policies that promote group cohesion and inclusive participation in the nation-building process. The research findings possess the potential to contribute to a deeper understanding and effective management of majority-minority conflicts, which have undergone a recent transformation. The present study enhances our awareness of the diverse components and domains involved in contemporary social categorization processes. Additionally, it sheds light on the impact of these processes on intergroup relationships, specifically focusing on individuals' preferences for specific social categories.

4.4 Limitations

This study has some shortcomings that should be pointed up and also owing to the fact that each stage of this investigation utilized a unique set of procedures and samples for the collection of data. The shortcomings were:

First, in phase I, we used only a single open-ended question provided in everyday discrimination scale (EDS) to generate the nodes and it was fulfilling our research purpose. As a result, the interviews with the participants were very brief, which reduced the amount of information that could be obtained from them. At the same time, significant efforts were made to limit the topic discussion that took place during the interviews. This is because, when conducting research, it is necessary to remain consistent with the objectives and proposed aim of the study and to avoid deviating from it at any point. However, longer conversations always seemed to have the potential to uncover even more profound insights. This finding was made by the researcher; future researchers are not compelled to agree with it.

Second, the data acquired in the first stage of this study are representative of the population of interest. These study participants tended to have a wide range of personal and cultural experiences, which resulted in greater findings but also broadened the scope of the data collected during the second phase of the research.

Third, in second phase, empirical studies within this thesis are limited in that they only focus on participants' response to social categories which do little to clarify our understanding in personally relevant situations.

Fourth, given that the manner in which social categorization and its corresponding intergroup relations are contingent upon contextual factors, it is important to acknowledge that a possible drawback of this current study is the potential influence of participants' cultural backgrounds on the obtained results.

Fifth, one potential constraint on the generalizability of the findings may arise from the selection of the samples utilized. Due to the fact that our participants were drawn from a collectivist society, it is important to acknowledge that the generalizability of the findings to the entire human species, encompassing diverse cultures, may be limited. This is because there is a possibility of observing distinct patterns of dominant social categories within societies that are individualistic, as highlighted by Henrich et al. (2010).

Finally, the interpretation of our results regarding the comparative predictive power of each of the statistical analyses in this study should be approached with caution. It is important to consider that each of the constructs examined can be operationalized in various ways. Therefore, the information provided here should be

interpreted with caution while taking into account the specific operationalization and operational definitions employed in this research, as indicated in different sections of the thesis introduction.

4.5 Future Directions

The findings of this current study bring to light a number of significant concerns that can be investigated in subsequent research: First, in this research we took adults as sample so future researches should continue to examine changing bases of social categorization and intergroup relationship with younger children in real life setting to better understand the full developmental trajectory.

Second, we believe that the notions and mechanisms of intergroup identification (in-group-out-group identification), as well as social distance, have the potential to significantly expand our knowledge of the social categorization mechanism and the intergroup relationship that is connected with it.

Third, future researched can aim at incorporating multilevel approaches to understand social categorization process, the utilization of constructs at both the individual and group levels in social categorization studies would provide higher clarity on new forms of categorizations and their expression in everyday life of an individual in a diverse country like India.

Fourth, we utilized dichotomous dimensions of social categories or reduced to dichotomous dimensions for cross-categorization additionally future researches can adopt a multiple categorization approach and can add more dimensions of social categories.

Fifth, there is a scarcity of research examining the extent to which the cognitive processes involved in intergroup relations, as observed in investigations employing crossed categorization with two dimensions, can be applied to scenarios involving multiple categorizations with more than two characteristics (Grigoryan, 2019b, 2019a; Urada et al., 2007). Therefore, with this data sheet we can investigate this cogitative aspect of intergroup relationship phenomena in more detailed way with complex factorial research designs.

Sixth, future researches can focus on ethnocentric measures to assess the changing bases of social categorization process and intergroup relationships.

Seventh, it is suggested that subsequent investigations explore the hypotheses in individualistic cultures and not solely concentrate on individual-level factors influencing social distance and social categorization. It is also recommended to investigate societal-level predictors, necessitating the inclusion of cross-cultural studies in this field of inquiry.

Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University